of national self-consciousness through which an emerging nation might stake its claim simultaneously to singularity and to membership in a modern world. Such profession of national identity through the medium of progressive art was a cultural phenomenon as widespread in Eastern Europe as it was rare in the west. Among the developed political states of Western Europe, modern national identity has been (and remains) the province of politicians and statesmen and only incidentally the concern of the artists; but then the nations of the West have often been free to express their identities politically.'[38]

In parts of Central Europe, mostly Slovenian and Croat lands, this national revival was briefly interrupted but also encouraged by the short-lived French occupation in the form of the so-called Illyrian provinces. This five-year period encouraged the use of vernacular and helped spread the values of the French Revolution among the few intellectuals, though the local Slovenian population did not honour the occasional desecration of churches by individual French soldiers and certainly did not avail themselves of the civil marriage option introduced by the French. But the Enlightenment spirits unleashed by this transitory French episode were strong enough that Valentin Vodnik, a Slovenian Catholic priest (!) welcomed the French, as restorers of a Slavic entity, with a poem. A century later, in 1929, a monument to Napoleon – reportedly the only statue to the French statesman outside France – was unveiled in Ljubljana to honour the centenary of the Illyrian Provinces and to strengthen the then Yugoslav-French alliance.

With the French or without them, towards the end of the nineteenth century, the nationalist movements in Eastern Europe culminated in demands that the Slavic nations should at least have autonomy within the Austrian Empire. However, there was no general consensus as to how this was to be achieved; before the end of World War I, not all Slavs thought of fully independent states. Most hoped that a federal solution within the empire could be reached, others that the help of the Allies, including Russia, should be sought. Amongst German and Austrian politicians, a minority were sympathetic to the ideas of federalism but most were carried along on the tide of ethnic German nationalism. Austria (and Hungary) feared losing access to the Adriatic, and losing Bosnia to Serbia. Above all, Austrians were scared of an outright end to the empire, something that eventually happened perhaps precisely because of the way the crisis was handled